

DETERMINERS

CBSE Grammar Notes • Classes 9–10

What is a Determiner?

A determiner comes before a noun to show which one, whose, how many, or how much.

Type	Examples	What it tells us
Articles	a, an, the	general / specific
Demonstratives	this, that, these, those	which noun
Possessives	my, your, his, her, its, our, their	whose
Quantifiers	some, any, much, many, few, little...	quantity
Distributives	each, every, either, neither, both, all	distribution / group
Numerals	one, two, first, second...	number / order
Interrogatives	which, what, whose	question before a noun

Golden idea: Always look at the noun after the blank. Its number, countability and meaning usually tell you which determiner fits.

1. Articles — A, An, The

A / An

Use with a singular countable noun when it is not specific or is mentioned for the first time.

- I saw a dog near the gate.
- She wants to buy a bicycle.
- He is an engineer.
- We waited for an hour.

Sound rule: A/An depends on pronunciation: a university, a European, but an umbrella, an honest man.

The

Use for a specific, known, unique or clearly identified noun.

- I saw a dog. The dog was friendly.
- Please close the door.
- The Earth moves around the Sun.
- This is the best answer.

Zero Article

Often used with plural/uncountable nouns in a general sense and with many proper names.

- Books are useful.
- Water is essential for life.
- She studies English.
- We visited India last year.

High-yield: the Ganga, the Himalayas, the United States; but usually India, France, Mount Everest.

2. Demonstrative Determiners

This / These → relatively near. That / Those → relatively far.

- This book is mine.
- These shoes are comfortable.
- Who owns that car?
- Look at those birds.

Number rule: This/That + singular countable noun; These/Those + plural noun.

3. Possessive Determiners

They show ownership or relationship and normally come before a noun.

- This is my book.
- Where is your bag?
- She called her brother.
- The students completed their project.

Remember: my pen uses a determiner; The pen is mine uses a possessive pronoun.

4. Quantifiers

Some / Any

- I bought some apples.
- There is some milk in the fridge.
- I don't have any money.
- Do you have any questions?

Tip: Some is common in affirmative sentences; any is common in negatives and questions. Some is also natural in offers/requests.

Much / Many

- There isn't much water.
- How much time do we have?
- She has many books.
- How many students are present?

Much → uncountable | Many → plural countable

Few / A Few / The Few

- Few students understood it. (almost none)

- A few students stayed back. (some)
- I have a few friends in Delhi.
- He spent the few coins he had.

Few-family → plural countable nouns.

Little / A Little / The Little

- There is little hope of success. (almost none)
- There is a little water left. (some)
- She showed a little patience.
- He used the little money he had.

Little-family → uncountable nouns.

Several / Enough / Plenty of

- She has visited several countries.
- There are enough chairs for everyone.
- We have enough food.
- There is plenty of time to finish.

These express sufficient or more-than-small quantities.

5. Distributive Determiners

Each / Every

- Each student received a certificate.
- Every child needs care.
- Each of the players brought his or her kit.
- Every room has a window.

Each / Every + singular countable noun. Each emphasizes members separately; every normally refers to all members individually as a group.

Either / Neither

- Either answer is acceptable.
- You can take either road.
- Neither answer is correct.
- Neither student was absent.

Either / Neither → two people or things. In standard school grammar, use a singular noun after either/neither.

Both / All

- Both boys are ready.
- Both answers are correct.
- All students attended the class.
- All the water was used.

Both → two; all → more than two or an uncountable quantity.

6. Numeral Determiners

Cardinal numbers

Tell us how many.

- Three students won prizes.
- I bought five notebooks.
- There are twenty chairs in the room.
- She has two sisters.

Ordinal numbers

Tell us position or order.

- He stood first in the race.
- This is my second attempt.
- She lives on the third floor.
- Today is the fifth day.

Cardinal = quantity (one, two, three...) | Ordinal = order (first, second, third...).

7. Interrogative Determiners

Which, what and whose can come before a noun to form questions.

- Which book do you want?
- What subject do you like most?
- Whose pen is this?
- Which route should we take?

Which often suggests a limited choice; what asks more generally; whose asks about possession.

8. No / None

No + noun

- There is no water in the bottle.
- I have no idea.
- No student was late.
- There were no tickets left.

None

- I invited many people, but none came.
- None of the students was/were ready.
- None of the money was recovered.
- There were biscuits, but there were none left.

Contrast: no books | none | none of the books

★. Quick Revision Chart

Determiner	Use	Example
a / an	one, non-specific singular countable noun	a teacher, an hour
the	specific / known / unique	the book, the Sun
this / that	singular: near / far	this pen, that house
these / those	plural: near / far	these books, those cars
some / any	quantity	some milk, any questions
much / many	uncountable / plural countable	much time, many students
few / little	small quantity	few books, little water
each / every	members individually	each student, every child
either / neither	two alternatives	either option, neither answer
both / all	two / more than two or uncountable	both boys, all students
which / what / whose	questions before nouns	which book? whose bag?
no / none	zero quantity	no money, none left

⚠. Common CBSE Traps

- an university ❌ → a university ✓
- a hour ❌ → an hour ✓
- much students ❌ → many students ✓
- few water ❌ → little water ✓
- each students ❌ → each student ✓
- these book ❌ → these books ✓
- no any money ❌ → no money / not any money ✓

✓. Golden Rules to Remember

- First identify whether the noun is singular, plural, countable, or uncountable.
- For a/an, listen to the sound, not just the spelling.
- Remember: much/many, few/little, and each/every have different noun patterns.
- Either/neither refer to two; both refers to two; all refers to more than two or an uncountable quantity.
- Use no + noun, but none can stand alone.

📝. Practice Exercise — Choose the Correct Determiner

1. He is ___ honest man. (a / an)
2. I saw ___ elephant at the zoo. (a / an)
3. Please close ___ window. (a / the)
4. ___ books are useful sources of knowledge. (The / —)
5. ___ students in this room are preparing for the test. (These / This)
6. I don't have ___ money with me. (some / any)
7. How ___ students are absent today? (much / many)

8. There is ____ milk left in the glass. (a little / a few)
9. ____ students understood the difficult lecture. (Few / Little)
10. ____ student must carry his/her ID card. (Each / Many)
11. ____ of the two answers is correct. (Neither / All)
12. ____ boys were selected for the final round. (Both / Every)
13. There is ____ water in the tank. (no / none)
14. I asked several students, but ____ knew the answer. (none / no)
15. ____ book is yours — the red one or the blue one? (Which / What)
16. ____ bag is lying on the desk? (Whose / Which)
17. She came ____ in the race. (first / one)
18. We have ____ time to complete the project. (enough / many)
19. He has ____ friends in the new city. (a few / a little)
20. There are ____ chairs for all the guests. (enough / much)

✓. Answer Key

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|-------------|-------------|
| 1. an | 11. Neither |
| 2. an | 12. Both |
| 3. the | 13. no |
| 4. — | 14. none |
| 5. These | 15. Which |
| 6. any | 16. Whose |
| 7. many | 17. first |
| 8. a little | 18. enough |
| 9. Few | 19. a few |
| 10. Each | 20. enough |

Exam strategy: Look at the noun after the blank. Ask: singular/plural? countable/uncountable? specific/general? two or more than two? This usually eliminates the wrong options quickly.